



MANEESH AGNIHOTRI



SANJAY SOKHAR

CRORE MEMORIALS DATES BACK TO HER SHORT FIRST TERM AS CHIEF MINISTER IN 1995.

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Mayawati's obsession with multi-crore parks and memorials dates back to 1995 when she became chief minister for the first time and engaged a well-known Delhi-based architect to design the parks. Initially, Rs 25 crore were earmarked for her ambitious project in Gomti Nagar. The project was after Babasaheb Ambedkar "to mark the be-

ginning of societal change. It was the symbol of the empowerment of Dalits because the key of power was now in the hands of the Dalits". In each of her subsequent terms, she pursued her projects with renewed vigour, and several new projects were announced, costing several hundred crores of rupees (*see box*). In his court petition, Kant quoted the bizarre instance of Mayawati ordering one of her own statues be pulled

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AKHILESH YADAV, SP LEADER



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MAYAWATI, CHIEF MINISTER



down as it seemed to be dwarfed by that of her mentor Kanshi Ram, which stood alongside. There are charges that Rs 2,000 crore were diverted from different departments to the Culture Department, which had been sanctioned Rs 1,200 crore in 2008-09 and Rs 600 crore in 2009-10 for the construction of the parks and statues, a budget approved by the state legislature.

Kant's petition has also alleged that Mayawati's statues are being constructed in the name of the great Dalit leaders but "on close examination of the parks, it can be seen that they are being made only for the glorification of the chief minister". Fearing that Mayawati might refuse to understand the mood of the Supreme Court, he wants the apex court to stop further construction till the Government responds to the notice. In her defence, Mayawati said, "My rivals have been saying that a number schools, hospitals and factories could have been opened with the amount spent on construction of these parks and statues, but this is not correct." In her typical I-don't-care attitude, she has also denied the allegations that the Public Works Department (PWD) diverted the development funds to the construction work. "This is a part of the process of ideological empowerment of people (Dalits)," she says.

It was in 2005 that the Lucknow bench of the Allahabad High Court had